



Above The walnut sauce of *satsivi* is a favorite at winter festivities in Tbilisi, along with the juicy dumplings known as *khinkali* (top left)

Left Tbilisi has been the capital of Georgia almost continuously since its founding in the 5th century



Above Georgia's thriving wine industry can draw on more than 500 varieties of grapes, and most – 90 percent – are Georgian varieties

Georgian Wines

Relatively little-known outside the Caucasus and Russia, Georgian wine is superb, and Georgia may be the oldest area of wine production in the world – dating back to around 4000 BC, when locals buried it in the ground in clay jars to ferment. The main area for wine production is the **Kakheti region** in the east, in particular **Telavi**. Among the most distinctive of Georgian wines are semisweet reds such as **Pirosmani** or **Khvanchkara**. The country has an elaborate wine toasting tradition, which includes a *tamada* or toastmaster whose duty it is to propose suitable toasts throughout the course of a feast, and make sure no guest runs short of *gvino* (wine).

The Best Places to Eat Satsivi

Hotel Kopala moderate

With a terrace overlooking the old town, the Hotel Kopala is a great place to stay, and its restaurant – one of the finest in Tbilisi – has an excellent range of traditional Georgian dishes. Starched white tablecloths indoors give way to pretty wrought-iron tables and chairs on the lovely open terrace, where customers dine at a relaxed pace. This vantage point has unbeatable views of the Metekhi church and across the river to the Narikala fort, rising above the atmospheric streets and houses of the old town. Inside the restaurant, large floor-to-ceiling windows share the same view (as do most of the rooms in the hotel). The menu includes either *satsivi* or *bazhe*, together with other favorites such as juicy *shashlik* (kebabs) and various specials, such as stuffed mushrooms. Both *satsivi* and *bazhe* are served with warming, homey *gomi* – the preferred earthy accompaniment to these thick, fragrant sauces. Pick a wine from the extensive Georgian wine list, and enjoy a delicious dining experience with an unforgettable view.

8–10 Chekhov Street, Tbilisi; open noon–11 pm daily; www.kopala.ge

Also in Tbilisi

The large **Kolkheti** restaurant (+995 32 357153; *moderate*), on the bank of the Kura River, has long tables with comfortable wood and leather chairs, and a wide range of traditional dishes including *satsivi* made – unusually – with sturgeon and other fish. **Ortachala** (+995 32 788050; *moderate*) is another good choice in the Georgian capital. For an indulgence in *khinkali*, head for **Khinkliss Sakhli** (www.khinklissakhli.info-tbilisi.com; *inexpensive*) on Rustaveli Avenue, which specializes in *khinkali* in all their guises, along with other Georgian dishes.

Also in Georgia

There is no guarantee of finding *satsivi* on the menu in restaurants outside the Georgian capital, but one of the better bets if you're in Telavi is the **Hotel Rcheuli Marani** (www.rcheuli.ge; *moderate*), which has its own cellar restaurant, the Old Marani.

Around the World

The excellent (and appropriately named) **Tbilisi** (+44 20 7607 2536; *moderate*) restaurant on London's Holloway Road serves a delicious *satsivi*, among other Georgian dishes, including some mouthwateringly good entrée platters and super *khinkali*. They also serve Georgian wines such as the heady Pirosmani. **Little Georgia** (+44 20 7739 8154; *moderate*) and **Mimino** (www.mimino.co.uk; *moderate*) are two more excellent choices in London that both have regularly changing specials.